Suspicious Transaction Report (STR/SAR) Filing Guideline

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1. Purpose

This guideline explains how Aspire staff identify, escalate and file suspicious transaction reports (STRs, referred to internally as SARs) with the Suspicious Transaction Reporting Office, using the regulator's online reporting portal. It applies to all customer-facing, operations and compliance staff.

2. Filing deadline

Aspire must file a SAR with MAS within 24 hours of the determination that a transaction or activity is suspicious. The 24-hour clock starts at the moment the MLRO (or delegated deputy) records the determination in the case file, not at the time of the first alert. Staff must escalate internal suspicion reports to the MLRO without delay and in any case within 4 hours of forming the suspicion.

3. Triggers

• A single cross-border transfer exceeding the equivalent of SGD 50,000 with an unclear purpose.

• Frequent small transfers in a short period that appear to be structured to avoid limits.

• A confirmed true match to a sanctions list.

• Customer refusal to supply source-of-funds information, or documents suspected to be forged.

4. Red-flag typologies

Typology	Indicators
Structuring	Many transfers just below SGD 5,000 or similar internal thresholds, across several days or accounts
Rapid movement of funds	Funds received and sent out within 24 hours with no business rationale; account used as a pass-through
Shell company	No employees, virtual office address, nominee directors, mismatch between stated and actual business
Trade-based laundering	Invoices inconsistent with goods, over or under invoicing, high-risk trade routes
High-risk sector	Gambling, virtual assets or defence trade customers with unexplained wealth
Third-party funding	Payments from unrelated parties; card repayments from unknown accounts

5. Internal process

• Step 1: The employee raises an Internal Suspicion Report (ISR) in SupportDesk under category 'AML - restricted'. Do not discuss on open Aspire Hub channels.

• Step 2: The MLRO office assigns a case number in the format STR-YYYY-NNNN (for example STR-2026-0147) and opens a restricted case file.

• Step 3: A compliance investigator gathers account, transaction and KYC data and drafts the narrative within the 24-hour window.

• Step 4: The MLRO approves the determination and a second reviewer checks completeness.

• Step 5: The report is submitted through the regulator's online portal and the acknowledgement reference is recorded in the case file.

• Step 6: The MLRO decides on account restriction, enhanced monitoring or exit.

6. Report content

The narrative must answer who, what, when, where, how and why. Include customer identifiers, UBOs, account numbers (masked in internal chat), transaction dates and amounts in SGD and original currency, counterparties, the red flags observed and actions already taken. Attach supporting evidence in the portal's accepted formats.

7. Tipping-off prohibition

It is a criminal offence to disclose to the customer or any third party that a report has been or may be made, or that an investigation is underway, where this is likely to prejudice an investigation. Customer-facing staff must use approved holding scripts, for example, 'We are carrying out a routine review', and refer questions to the Compliance team. Breaches are treated as gross misconduct.

8. Records and review

SAR files, internal suspicion reports and decisions not to file are retained for at least 5 years. The MLRO reports monthly statistics (number of ISRs, filed reports, median time to file) to the Risk Committee. Case files carry the Secret handling label while active.